Singing the Blues

The most powerful and direct manner of expressing the blues is by singing. The earliest blues grew out of work songs, church songs, chants, and field hollers, and were sung unaccompanied. The guitar became the logical choice for an accompanying instrument, as it was relatively inexpensive, portable, and offered both rhythmic and harmonic capabilities. With this in mind let us examine the basic relationship between blues singing and the guitar accompaniment.

The Blues Lyric Form

The most commonly used form of the blues, as we've already discussed, is the twelve-bar form. The blues lyric divides these twelve bars into three sections taking up four bars each:

A *(opening statement)* I got these blues, Mama, I'm not satisfied.

A *(repeat of statement)* I got these blues, Mama, I'm not satisfied.

B *(answering statement)* Well, that's the reason I ran away and cried.

The music below shows how the lyrics fall across the twelve bars. In this tune each four-bar phrase starts on the *and* of the fourth count. *Pickup notes* like these are common in blues lyrics.

